

Analysis Report: World Happiness Data 2024 | Emotions Analysis

Report Title

Analysis Report of the World Happiness Data 2024

Introduction

The dataset used in this analysis is derived from the World Happiness Report 2024, an annual publication that evaluates subjective well-being and life satisfaction across countries worldwide. The World Happiness Report is produced by the Wellbeing Research Centre at the University of Oxford, in collaboration with Gallup, Inc. and the United Nations Sustainable Development Solutions Network (SDSN). The project is supported through institutional and research funding associated with these organisations and aims to provide evidence-based insights to inform global policy discussions related to well-being and social progress.

The data is primarily sourced from the Gallup World Poll, which conducts large-scale surveys in more than 140 countries using nationally representative samples. Respondents are asked to evaluate their overall quality of life using the Cantril Ladder scale, also referred to as the Life Ladder, which ranges from 0 (worst possible life) to 10 (best possible life). This standardised methodology allows for meaningful cross-country comparisons of happiness levels despite cultural and socioeconomic differences. Findings based on this dataset are published annually in the World Happiness Report and are widely referenced in academic research and international development studies.

The World Happiness 2024 dataset contains country-level indicators that capture multiple dimensions of well-being, including economic conditions, health outcomes, social relationships, emotional states, and institutional trust. These variables allow for comprehensive analysis of factors that may influence happiness across countries. To provide clarity on the dataset structure and support subsequent analysis, the key attributes used in this study are summarised in Table 1.

Attribute	Description
Country name	The country in which survey responses were collected. Each row represents one country.
Year	The year in which the survey data was recorded (2024).
Life Ladder	The national average happiness score measured using the Cantril Ladder scale, ranging from 0 (lowest life satisfaction) to 10 (highest life satisfaction).
Log GDP per capita	A logarithmic transformation of GDP per capita, representing the economic prosperity of a country.
Healthy life expectancy at birth	The average number of years a person is expected to live in good health, reflecting overall population health conditions.
Social support	Indicates whether respondents report having someone to rely on during difficult times, representing social connectedness.
Freedom to make life choices	Measures individuals' perceived freedom to make important decisions about their lives.

Generosity	Reflects charitable behaviour and willingness to help others, derived from survey responses.
Perceptions of corruption	Represents public perceptions of corruption within government and business institutions.
Positive affect	Measures the frequency of positive emotions such as happiness and enjoyment experienced by respondents.
Negative affect	Measures the frequency of negative emotions such as sadness, stress, and anger experienced by respondents.

Table 1: Description of World Happiness 2024 Dataset Attributes

Research Questions

Based on the attributes provided in the World Happiness 2024 dataset, this analysis aims to examine differences in happiness levels across countries and explore the socioeconomic and health-related factors associated with subjective well-being. The following research questions are formulated to guide the analysis:

- Which countries report the highest and lowest Life Ladder (happiness) scores in 2024?**
 This question focuses on identifying countries at the extremes of happiness levels and understanding global disparities in life satisfaction.
- Is there a relationship between economic prosperity (Log GDP per capita) and happiness scores across countries?**
 This question examines whether higher income levels are associated with higher reported happiness.
- How does healthy life expectancy at birth relate to happiness scores among different countries?**
 This question explores the role of population health as a contributing factor to subjective well-being.
- Do social and institutional factors, such as social support, freedom to make life choices, and perceptions of corruption, appear to influence happiness levels?**
 This question investigates non-economic factors that may contribute to variations in happiness across countries.

Finding Elaborations

Question 1

Which countries report the highest and lowest Life Ladder (happiness) scores in 2024?

Top 10 Countries by Happiness Score

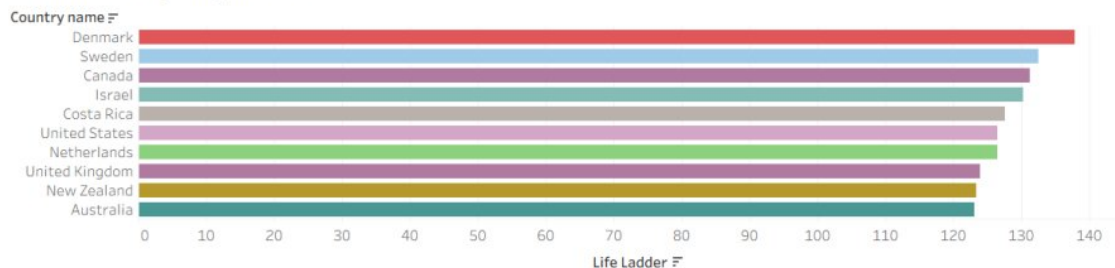


Figure 1. Top 10 Countries by Happiness Score

Figures 1 and 2 present the top 10 and bottom 10 countries ranked by Life Ladder scores in 2024. As shown in Figure 1, Denmark records the highest happiness score among the selected countries, followed closely by Sweden and Canada. Other countries appearing in the top 10 include Israel, Costa Rica, the United States, the Netherlands, the United Kingdom, New Zealand, and Australia. These countries are generally characterised by relatively high living standards, stable economies, and strong social support systems, which may contribute to higher levels of life satisfaction.

Bottom 10 Countries by Happiness Score

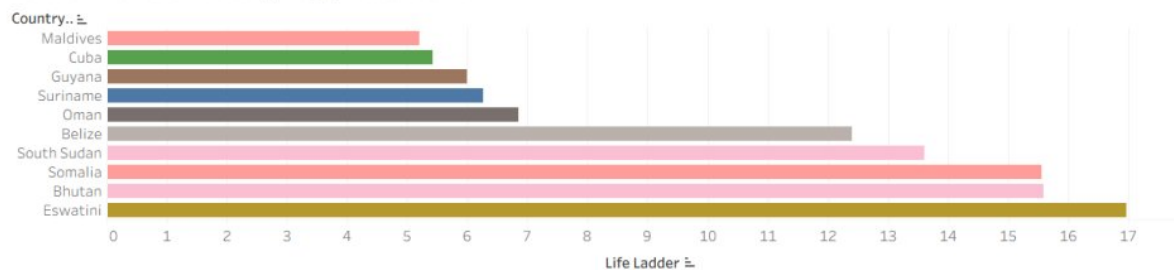


Figure 2. Bottom 10 Countries by Happiness Score

In contrast, Figure 2 illustrates the bottom 10 countries by happiness score. Countries such as Eswatini, Bhutan, Somalia, and South Sudan report the lowest Life Ladder scores, indicating significantly lower levels of subjective well-being. These lower scores may be associated with factors such as economic instability, limited access to healthcare and education, political challenges, or social insecurity. The clear contrast between the top and bottom groups highlights substantial global disparities in happiness levels across countries.

Overall, the comparison between the top 10 and bottom 10 countries demonstrates that happiness is unevenly distributed worldwide, with countries experiencing more stable socioeconomic conditions tending to report higher life satisfaction. This finding provides a foundation for further analysis of economic, health, and social factors influencing happiness in subsequent research questions.

Question 2

Is there a relationship between economic prosperity (Log GDP per capita) and happiness scores across countries?

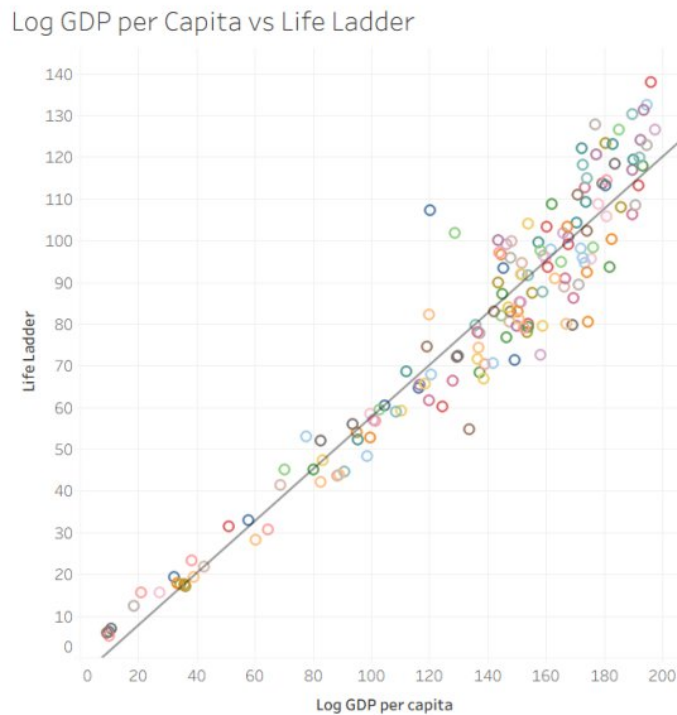


Figure 3 GDP per Capita vs Life Ladder

Figure 3 illustrates the relationship between Log GDP per capita and Life Ladder scores across countries in 2024. The scatter plot shows a clear upward trend, as supported by the fitted trend line, indicating a positive relationship between economic prosperity and happiness. In general, countries with higher Log GDP per capita tend to report higher Life Ladder scores, suggesting that greater economic resources are associated with higher levels of life satisfaction.

However, the dispersion of data points around the trend line indicates that countries with similar levels of economic prosperity can exhibit different happiness scores. This suggests that while income level is an important contributing factor to happiness, it does not solely determine subjective well-being. Other factors such as health, social support, and institutional conditions may also influence happiness outcomes. Overall, the findings indicate that economic prosperity plays a significant role in shaping happiness levels, but its impact is complemented by non-economic factors.

Question 3

How does healthy life expectancy at birth relate to happiness scores among different countries?

Healthy Life Expectancy vs Life Ladder

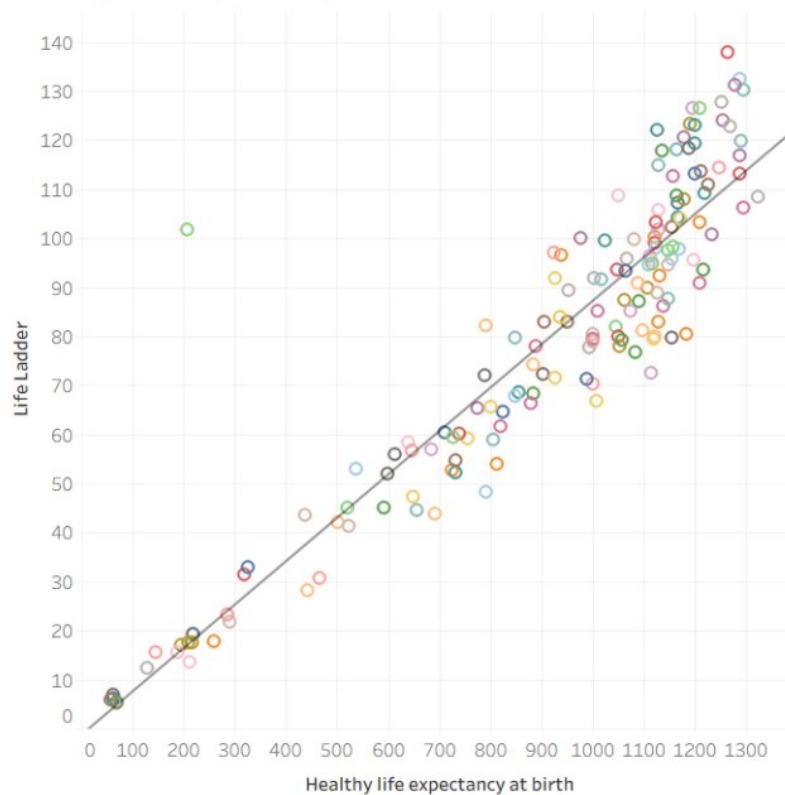


Figure 4. Health Life Expectancy at Birth vs Life Ladder

Figure 4 presents the relationship between healthy life expectancy at birth and Life Ladder scores across countries in 2024. The scatter plot demonstrates a clear positive relationship, as indicated by the upward trend line, where countries with higher healthy life expectancy tend to report higher happiness scores. This suggests that populations experiencing longer and healthier lives are generally more satisfied with their overall quality of life.

Although the overall trend is positive, some variation can be observed among countries with similar levels of healthy life expectancy, indicating that health alone does not entirely determine happiness. Nevertheless, the strong association highlights the importance of healthcare access, disease prevention, and overall living conditions as key contributors to subjective well-being. These findings emphasise that improvements in population health are closely linked to higher levels of life satisfaction across countries.

Question 4

Do social and institutional factors, such as social support, freedom to make life choices, and perceptions of corruption, appear to influence happiness levels?

Figures 5, 6, and 7 illustrate the relationships between Life Ladder scores and three social and institutional factors: social support, freedom to make life choices, and perceptions of corruption.

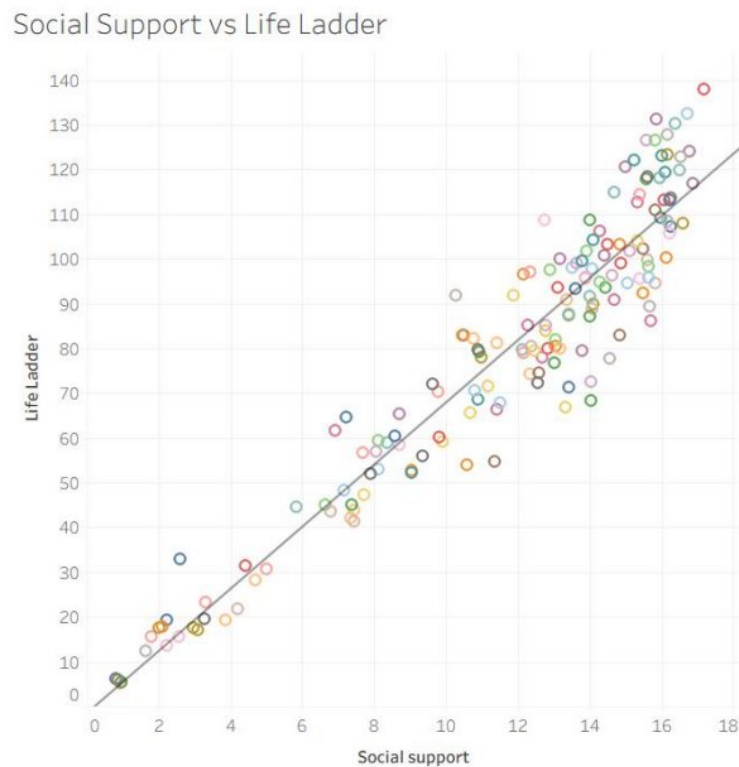


Figure 5. Social Support vs Life Ladder

As shown in Figure 5, the scatter plot reveals a strong positive relationship between social support and happiness. Countries where individuals report stronger social support networks tend to exhibit higher Life Ladder scores, indicating that having reliable personal and community support plays a significant role in shaping subjective well-being.

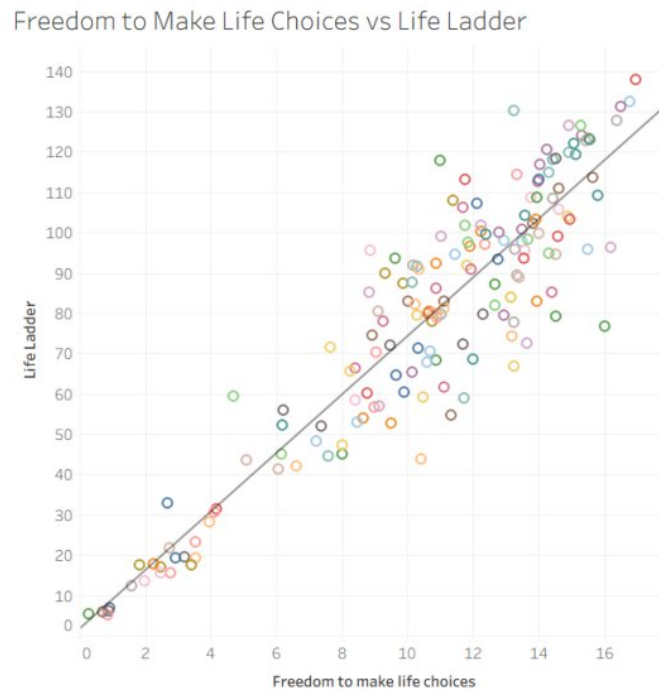


Figure 6. Freedom to Make Life Choices vs Life Ladder

Similarly, Figure 6 demonstrates a positive association between freedom to make life choices and happiness levels. Countries with higher perceived freedom generally report higher Life Ladder scores, suggesting that personal autonomy and the ability to make independent life decisions contribute positively to life satisfaction. Although some variation exists among countries with similar freedom levels, the overall upward trend indicates a meaningful relationship.

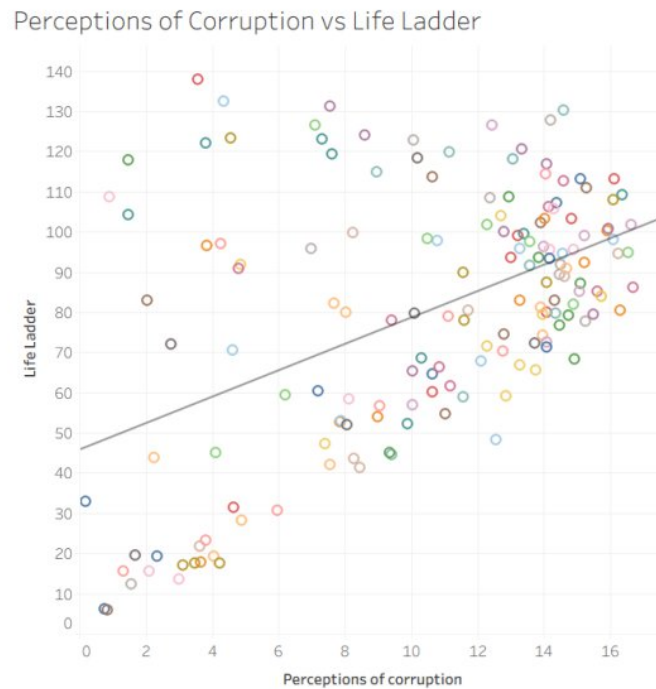


Figure 7. Perceptions of Corruption vs Life Ladder

In contrast, Figure 7 shows a weaker and more dispersed relationship between perceptions of corruption and happiness. While countries with lower perceived corruption tend to report slightly higher happiness scores, the trend is less pronounced compared to social support and freedom to make life choices. This suggests that although institutional trust influences happiness, its impact may be more indirect or moderated by other social and economic factors.

Overall, the findings indicate that social and institutional factors do influence happiness levels across countries. Among the factors examined, social support and freedom to make life choices show stronger associations with happiness, while perceptions of corruption exhibit a weaker relationship. These results highlight the importance of social relationships and personal autonomy, alongside institutional conditions, in understanding variations in subjective well-being.

Conclusion and Recommendations

Conclusion

This analysis examined global happiness levels in 2024 using the World Happiness dataset, focusing on economic, health, social, and institutional factors influencing subjective well-being. The findings show significant disparities in happiness across countries, with economically stable nations generally reporting higher Life Ladder scores. Economic prosperity, measured by Log GDP per capita, demonstrates a positive relationship with happiness, although income alone does not fully explain variations in life satisfaction.

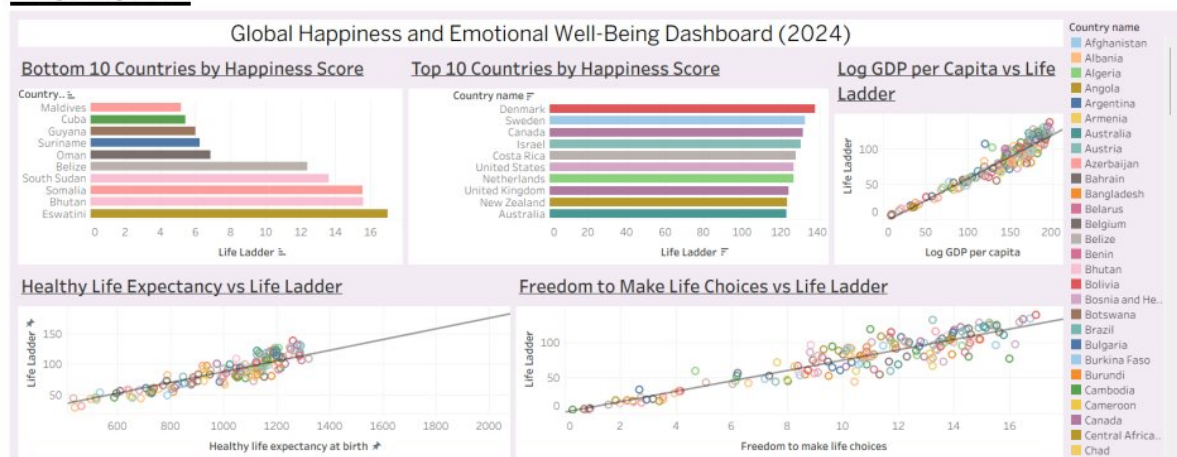
Health outcomes, particularly healthy life expectancy at birth, also exhibit a strong positive association with happiness, highlighting the importance of population health in shaping well-being. In addition, social and institutional factors play a critical role. Strong social support networks and greater freedom to make life choices show clear positive relationships with happiness, while perceptions of corruption display a weaker but noticeable influence. Overall, the results indicate that happiness is a multidimensional concept shaped by a combination of economic, health, and social conditions rather than a single factor.

Recommendations

Based on the findings, several recommendations can be proposed. Governments and policymakers should prioritise policies that support economic stability alongside investments in healthcare systems to improve population health and longevity. In addition, strengthening social support structures and promoting personal freedom can contribute significantly to improving overall life satisfaction.

Organisations such as national governments, public health agencies, and international development bodies (e.g., the United Nations and non-governmental organisations) may benefit from these findings when designing policies aimed at enhancing quality of life. Future initiatives should adopt a holistic approach to well-being, recognising that improvements in happiness require coordinated efforts across economic, health, and social domains.

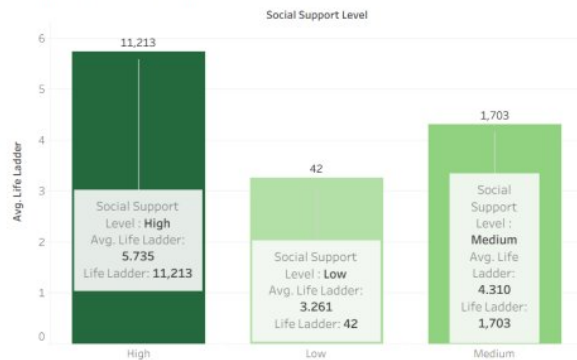
DASHBOARD



Do social and institutional factors influence happiness levels

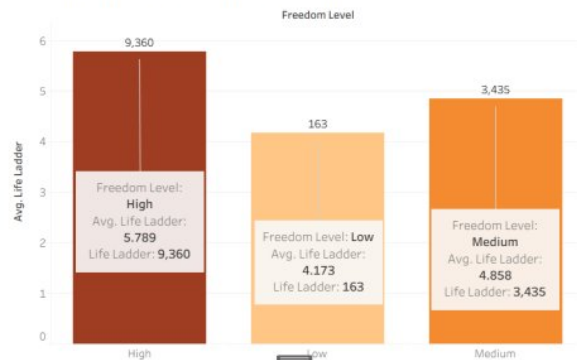
Social and institutional factors, such as social support, freedom to make life choices, and perceptions of corruption, play an important role in shaping individual well-being. This section explores how these factors relate to happiness levels across countries in 2024, helping to identify which non-economic conditions contribute to higher life satisfaction.

Social support x Happiness



There is a **positive relationship** between social support and happiness. Countries where people feel more supported by family, friends, or community tend to report higher life satisfaction. Low social support corresponds to lower happiness, highlighting the importance of social connections in well-being.

Freedom to Make Life Choices vs Happiness



Greater freedom to make important life choices is associated with higher happiness. People in countries with more personal autonomy tend to report higher life satisfaction, while limited freedom corresponds to lower happiness levels.

References

World Happiness Report. (2024). *World Happiness Report 2024*. Sustainable Development Solutions Network. <https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/abdullah0a/world-happiness-data-2024-explore-life>